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How to create FoF map thumbnails (2025)

By [WL/S^3] Weasel (Probably AFK)

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NOTE: UNDER-CONSTRUCTION STILL

Guide for to creating *map preview thumbnails* for the **Highlighted Server Browser** (**HSB**) feature of Fistful of Frags (**FoF**). This is mostly something that might be relevant to either:

- Map authors creating new maps for **FoF** - so that when game-servers running their maps are shown in the **HSB** a thumbnail preview of what the map actually looks-like will be displayed - instead of the generic "Custom Map" icon.
- Game-server operators for **FoF** - who might be running custom/community maps which pre-date the **HSB** system entirely, or for which the map author did not create and distribute a related thumbnail.

Award Favorited Share

0 - Revision History Edit

Be sure to check here for anything that may have changed, since the last time you read-through or used this guide.

NOTE: Latest updates at the top,

Revision Date	Revision Notes
20250315	Initial creation, pre-publication.

1 - About the HSB and preview thumbnails Edit

Some information about the **HSB** and map preview thumbnails:

- This is the screen you see when you first enter the game, showing thumbnail preview images of different maps running on available game-servers. Because of its visual nature (images),

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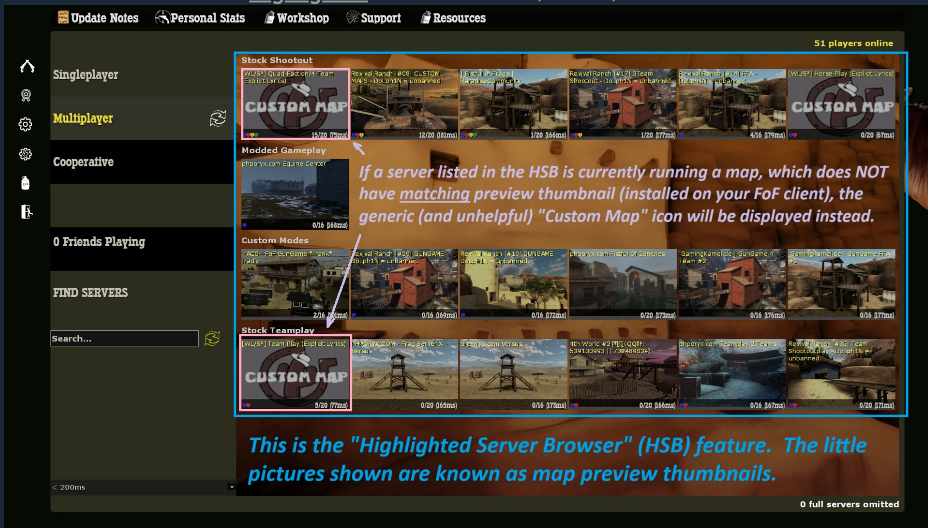
this is referred-to as the **Highlighted Server Browser** (or **HSB**).



- This feature is how most Fistful of Frags (**FoF**) players find and connect to servers to play the game. This is *especially* true for those new to the game.
- Having a map preview thumbnail shown is *extremely helpful* to players, who may only recognize maps by what they look-like visually. Also the **HSB**, does not by itself show the **name** of the map currently being run by the server - only a matching preview thumbnail or the generic "Custom Map" icon.
- Unfortunately, **FoF** currently only includes preview thumbnails for maps that shipped with the game at the time of its last update - nearly **two** (**2**) years ago. So no preview thumbnails are included for any custom maps released by the community - resulting in the generic "**Custom Map**" icon being shown instead of an actual map preview.
- Ideally map authors, would create preview thumbnails for the maps and include them when they distribute the maps. However, many (mostly really) map authors are currently unfamiliar with this process, in part because (as far as I can determine) its not well documented. Also, many custom / community maps pre-date the existence of the **HSB** feature entirely.
- That's correct, the HSB *did not even exist* in earlier releases of **FoF**.
- This guide aims to remedy that situation - for both **map authors** *creating* new maps for **FoF**, as well as for **server operators** *hosting* community maps on their **FoF** game-servers.

2 - Prerequisites (things you need to proceed) Edit

Some things you will need (assuming you are doing this on **Windows**) are:

- Fistful of Frags already installed.
- Whichever **map** (you are making a thumbnail for) installed in the **fof/maps** sub-folder.
- **Any text editor**. For these examples, **Windows Notepad** will be used - since it is widely available.
- **Paint.NET** - available here [www.getpaint.net] . You may actually use any imaged editor *with equivalent features*. Unfortunately, **Windows Paint** will *not* easily suffice.
- VTFEdit [github.com] for converting the image file into Valve's proprietary VTF texture format (more info here)
- VIDE [www.riintouge.com] for manipulating the map BSP file (more info here)
- 7-Zip [www.7-zip.org] for various file/folder compression tasks.

Note: For those wishing to do this on **Linux** (Linux Mint [linuxmint.com] being my personal favorite for desktop Linux installations), the key *differences* and your key *equivalents* are probably:

- Obviously, the **paths** for everything will be *different*, and the **screens** will *not look the same*.
- Whatever default **text-editor** comes with your Linux distribution.
- Whatever **image editor** you prefer (Pinta [www.pinta-project.com] , Gimp [www.gimp.org] , etc.).
- VIDE [www.riintouge.com] is actually available for Linux also! (although, I have not tried it myself).
- VIDE [www.riintouge.com] has a built-in function similar to VTFEdit [github.com] that should suffice (although, I have not tried it myself).

3 - Capturing a screenshot to use Edit

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GUIDE INDEX

Generally, it is best practice to base the map preview thumbnail on a screenshot of the map, in order to best present what that map looks like to the player. However, *if you are the map author*, alternative option might be to create some *artistic representation* of the map - if you feel that would better represent the map. For the purposes of this guide, I will use a screenshot as the basis for the preview thumbnail.

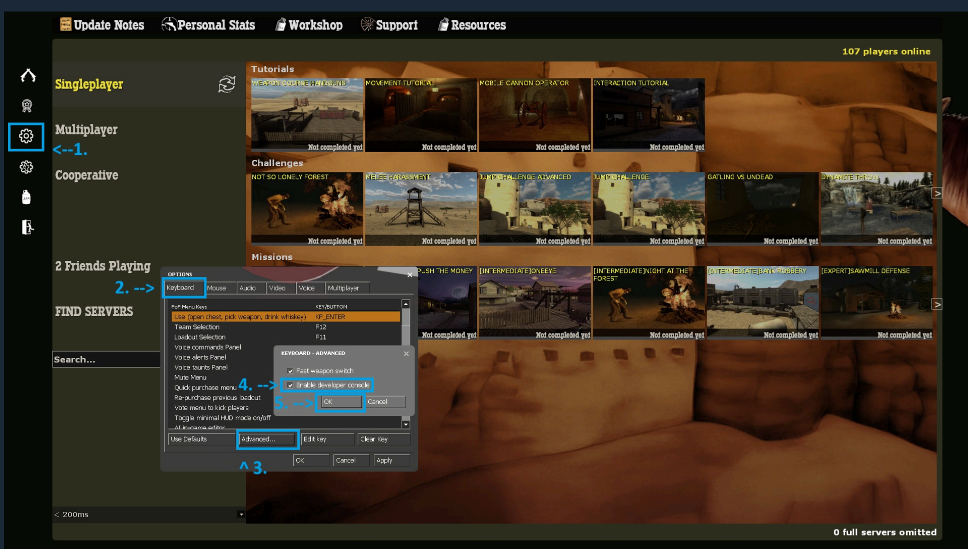
Overall process:

At a high-level the part of the process is:

- Launch Fistful of Frags (**FoF**).
- Make sure the "developer console" is **enabled**. *If you are not sure how to do this*, see the notes and image below for how to do this.
- Start a game using the **map** you wish to create a preview thumbnail for. Be sure that you also configure the game for the appropriate **FoF** *game-mode* the map requires. *If you are not sure how to do this*, see the notes and image below for how to do this.
- If you have **net_graph** enabled, *turn it off* (e.g. set **net_graph 0**).
- Switch to spectator mode (e.g. change to the **Spectator** team).
- Move around in spectator mode until you have a good point-of-view on-screen the best represents what this map is like (and that players will later recognize it as).
- Capture a screenshot, and save it to a file you can edit.

Enabling the "Developer Console":

- Open the **options** menu, by clicking the **gear-shaped** icon the left-side of the screen.
- Make sure you have the "**Keyboard**" tab selected/shown.
- Click the "**Advanced**" button.
- Ensure that the "**Enable developer console**" option is selected/checked.
- Click the "**Ok**" button to close that dialog.
- Be aware that (by default) you toggle the developer console open and closed using the **tilde** ("~") key. You can also re-map this to another key if you desire. It is listed in the **Keyboard** tab as "toggle console".
- If you are done making changes, click the "**Ok**" on the options dialog to close that screen.



Starting a game (locally) with the desired map:

- Launch Fistful of Frags (**FoF**).
- Press the **tilde** ("~") key - or whichever key you have "toggle console" bound-to.
- The **developer console** window should open.
- This **developer console** is essentially a command-line interface [en.wikipedia.org] - where you can enter various text-based commands, one-line at a time.
- Set the **fof_sv_currentmode** *console variable* (or **CVAR**) to the mode that the map is compatible with.
- For example, enter this command and press **ENTER** to set the game for **FoF** "Shoot-Out" mode (used by maps with names starting with "**fof_**":

```
fof_sv_currentmode 1
```

- Alternatively, enter this command and press **ENTER** to set the game for **FoF** "Team-Play" mode (used by maps with names starting with "**tp_**":

```
fof_sv_currentmode 2
```

- The full list of possible game-modes are:

```
1 = Deathmatch and/or Team-Deathmatch
2 = Team-based Objectives, Zone-Capture, etc.
3 = Break Bad
4 = Elimination
5 = Versus
6 = Cooperative
```

- The command to start the game (using the map of your choice), is the *not-ironically-named* "**map**" command. Simply enter "**map**", followed by a space, then the name of the map you want to start, and then press **ENTER**. For example:

```
map fof_cripplecreek
```

Capturing a screenshot:

Move around the map in **FoF** in "spectator" mode, and find point-of-view that you think would best show most to a player *which* map this is - for them to *recognize* it easily later.

Using **Steam**'s screenshot feature:

- Use whatever hot-key you have setup for Steam's screenshot function. The default if **F12**.
- Close **FoF**.
- *Right-click* on the Steam icon in the bottom-right corner of the Windows task-bar.
- Select the **Screenshots** option.
- Browse through the recent screenshot and click on the one you want to use.
- *Right-click* on the image, and select the **Copy to clipboard** option.
- Open your image editor (**Paint.NET** or whatever editor you are using) and paste the clipboard contents into it.
- Save a copy of the image somewhere you can find it easily.

4 - Resizing and editing the screenshot Edit

Using **Paint.NET** (or whatever other imaged editor you using), open the copy of the screenshot you saved earlier.

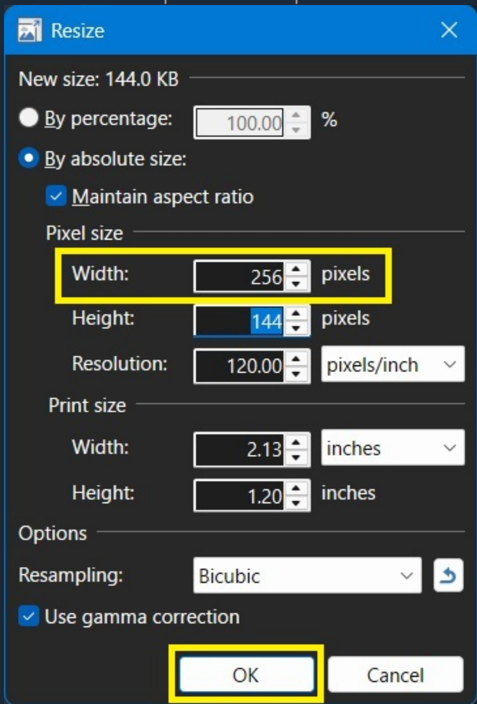
Overall, here is what you need to accomplish at this stage:

- Open the screenshot.
- Resize it to a **width** of (*exactly*) **256 pixels**.
- Allow the **height** to be *resized proportionally* automatically.
- Resize the image "canvas" to be *exactly* **256x256** pixels, the with existing image contents being *centered* on the newly-expanded canvas.
- Optionally, darken the image some to allow the (later added) text to stand-out better.
- Optionally, overlay text on the **center** of the image - containing ***name** of the map*.
- Save the image someplace you can find it later.

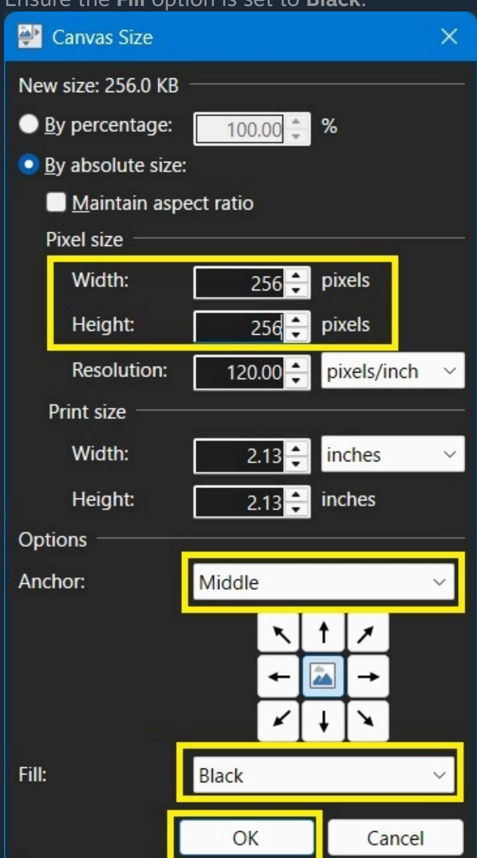
Specifically, in **Paint.NET** that is accomplished by doing this:

- Open the screenshot.
- Select the"**Resize...** option from the **Image** menu.

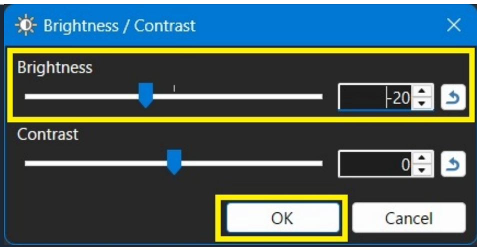
- Set the **Width** option to **256** pixels.



- Click **Ok** to apply the image resize change.
- Select the"**Canvas size...** option from the **Image** menu.
- Set the **Height** option to **256** pixels.
- Ensure the **Anchor** option is set to **Middle**.
- Ensure the **Fill** option is set to **Black**.



- Click **Ok** to apply the canvas resize change.
- Select the"**Brightness / Contrast** option from the **Adjustments** menu.
- Adjust the **Brightness** option to darken the image some (in particular if it is an outdoor daylight map) to allow the text (that you will apply next) show to better.



- Click **Ok** to apply the brightness change.
- Press **F8** to open the color-selection tool.
- In the color-selection tool, select which color you want to use for the text. I strongly suggest some shade of **yellow** - in keeping with **FoF**'s dusty look.
- Select the **Text** tool from the left-side tool-bar (Hint: It looks like a capital "T").
- Click on the image, type the name of the map. Reposition the resultant text as needed to get it approximately centered.
- Save the (now resized, darkened and labeled) image someplace you can find it later.

The evolution of the image (from screenshot to thumbnail) should look something like this:

5 - Converting to Valve-proprietary "texture" format Edit

Once you have the thumbnail-sized image created in the correct size (exactly **256 x 256 pixels**) with the visual content you like, the next step is to convert it to the Valve-proprietary VTF that is used by the Source game-engine for handling images.

Background and Caveats:

Obviously, being a "thumbnail" it is easy to understand why having the original image be so small is desirable. There is no point in wasting memory or CPU in-game to resize a large image dynamically down to a thumbnail size on the fly. It is less of a resource burden to just have it drawn on-screen as a natively smaller size - or in **FoF**'s case resized from a small size to another small size.

The reason for the *exact* **256 pixel by 256 pixel** size, is a bit more technical. If you ever had cause to make a custom in-game "texture" to use as part of a new map, then you are probably already familiar with this. But, I will discuss it a bit here for the benefit of those not already familiar with it (i.e. server operators, etc.).

Most game-engines (including Source, which **FoF** is based-on) only work with images whose *dimensions* are *even* **powers-of-two**. They do not necessarily have to be specifically *square*, but *both dimensions* must be even **powers-of-two**. These would include either **X** or **Y** axis being numbers such as:

- 16
- 32
- 64
- 128
- 256
- 512
- 1024

As a result, some example images sizes might include:

- 128 x 128 (square)
- 256 x 256 (square)
- 128 x 256 (rectangular, horizontal)
- 256 x 128 (rectangular, vertical)

Additionally, the Fistful of Frags "**Highlighted Server Browser**" (**HSB**) feature does some further manipulation of the **VTF** (dynamically *resizing* and *cropping*) when displaying it. Apparently, the **HSB** feature requires/expects the original thumbnail to be *exactly* **256x256 pixels**.

Although the **VTF** is square, the thumbnails are largely based on screen-captures with either a 4:3 or 16:9 screen ratio. As a result, although the **VTF** is **256x256** pixels (square), the image gets *resized slightly* and *cropped* to roughly **238x162** pixels (a *roughly* **4:3** ratio) when displayed in the **HSB**.

This is why when *resizing the **canvas*** of the original image earlier, it was important to **center** the content in the middle of the resized canvas. Additionally, the resultant black bands at the top and the bottom (although *partially* cut-off by the on-screen resizing/cropping) provide good contrast for the *lighter-colored text* that the **HSB** will overlay on the thumbnail with information about the server.

Further, the way the Valve-proprietary VTF system works, **VMT** files (referred to as "textures") are typically accompanied by **VMT** files (referred to as "materials"). A material may actually have multiple different textures associated with it. Think of the **VTF** as the image portion, and the **VMT** as the *meta-data* that provides the game-engine (Source) additional information it need to know how to use it properly.

The Process:

The to accomplish the format conversion, is by using the free VTFEdit [github.com] utility. Alternatively, VIDE [www.riintouge.com] has a built-in function similar to VTFEdit [github.com] that should suffice (although, I have not tried it myself).

Overall the process is essentially:

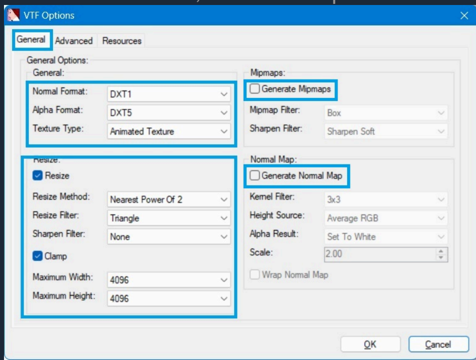
- Open VTFEdit [github.com] .
- Ensure automatic **VMT** creation is *enabled*.
- **Import** your existing image.
- Set the **VTF Options** *correctly*.
- Save the resultant **VTF** with the *expected naming-convention*.

Example, Part-1 (VTF):

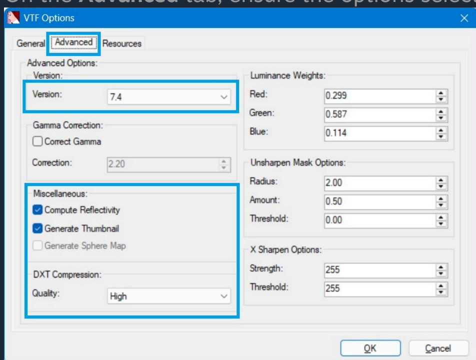
Continuing the example, using the image from earlier sections:

- Open VTFEdit [github.com] .
- Ensure the **Auto Create VMT File** option *is checked* the **Options** menu.
- Select **Import** from the **File** menu, and select the thumbnail image you have made.
- The **VTF Options** dialog should pop-up, asking that properties you want for this **VTF**.

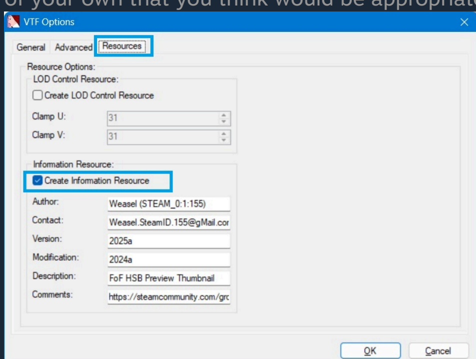
- On the **General** tab, ensure the options selected match what is shown in this image:



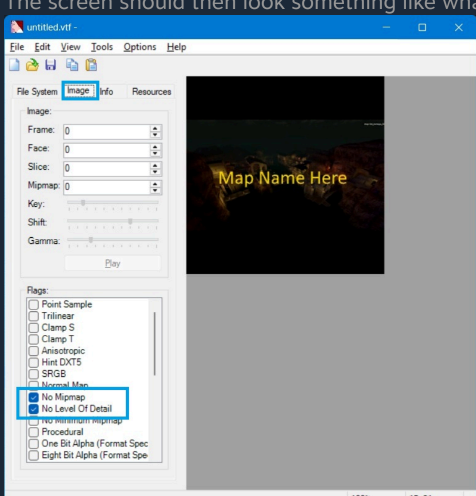
- On the **Advanced** tab, ensure the options selected match what is shown in this image:

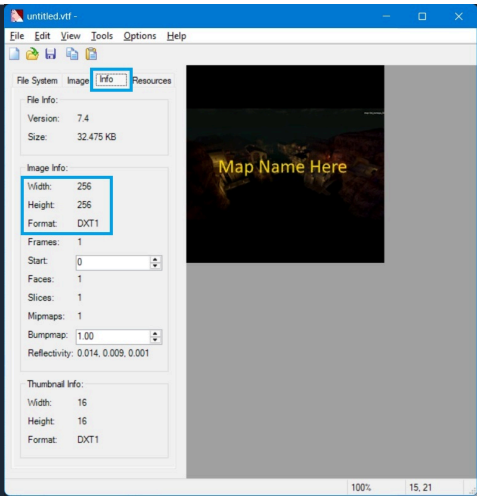


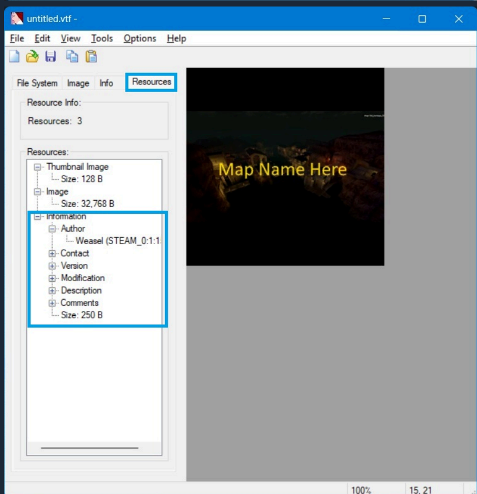
- Optionally, on the **Resources** tab, enable the **Create Information Resource** option and fill-out the information in a similar manner as shown in this image - but with whatever information of your own that you think would be appropriate:



- Click the **Ok** button to close the **VTF Options** dialog.
- The screen should then look something like what is shown in the following images:







- Select **Save** from the **File** menu to save the file. Be sure to name the file with the following convention: "**menu_thumb_**" (exactly) followed by the exact map name. For example:

```
menu_thumb_fof_somemapname.vtf
```

NOTE: The **.vtf** part should be added automatically.

Example, Part-2 (VMT): - *No, you are **not** done yet!*

Since you enabled **Auto Create VMT Files**, when you saved the **VTF**, the utility should have also created a matching **.vmt** file *in the same location*.

- Open the **.vmt** file in a *text-editor* (Windows Notepad, Notepad++ or whatever you use).
- The existing content will look something like this:

```
"LightmappedGeneric"
{
        "$basetexture" "blah/blah/blah/menu_thumb_fof_somenewmap"
}
```

- Replace the contents with the equivalent of this, ***substituting*** *the actual name of the map* instead of "fof_somenewmap":

```
"UnlitGeneric"
{
        "$baseTexture" "vgui\maps/menu_thumb_fof_somenewmap"
        "$translucent" 1
        "$ignorez" 1
        "$vertexcolor" 1
        "$nolod" "1"
}
```

- Save the updated **.vmt** file.

You will notice that the final **.vmt** file contains the path "**vgui\maps**". This path is *relative to the* ***fof/materials*** *sub-folder* of your Fistful of Frags installation. For example:

```
C:\Program Files (x86)\Steam\steamapps\common\Fistful of Frags\fof\materials
```

Consequently, map preview thumbnails for all custom maps in **FoF** are stored (assuming a default installation on Windows), here:

```
C:\Program Files (x86)\Steam\steamapps\common\Fistful of Frags\fof\materials\vgui\maps
```

NOTE: **Always** keep the resultant *matching* **.vtf** and **.vmt** files *together - in the same folder.*

6 - Including with the map (Method-1: RES file inclusion) Edit

7 - Including with the map (Method-2: Embedding in the BSP) Edit

8 - Distributing through game-servers Edit

9 - Distributing though the community thumbnail archive Edit